

Introduction to prompting

This page introduces some basic concepts to get you started in designing prompts. A prompt is a natural language request submitted to a language model to receive a response back. Prompts can contain questions, instructions, contextual information, few-shot examples, and partial input for the model to complete or continue. After the model receives a prompt, depending on the type of model being used, it can generate text, embeddings, code, images, videos, music, and more.

What is prompt design and prompt engineering

Prompt design is the process of creating prompts that elicit the desired response from language models. Writing well structured prompts can be an essential part of ensuring accurate, high quality responses from a language model. The iterative process of repeatedly updating prompts and assessing the model's responses is sometimes called *prompt engineering*.

Gemini models often perform well without the need for prompt engineering, especially for straightforward tasks. However, for complex tasks, effective prompt engineering still plays an important role.

Components of a prompt

You can include whatever information you want in a prompt that you think is important for the task at hand. Generally, prompt content fall within one of the following components:

- Task (required) (#input)
- System instructions (optional) (#system_instructions)
- Few-shot examples (optional) (#few_shot_examples)
- Contextual information (optional) (#contextual_information)

Task

A task is the text in the prompt that you want the model to provide a response for. Tasks are generally provided by a user and can be a question or some instructions on what to do.

Example question task:

:

are the colors in the rainbow?

se:

rainbow has seven colors: red, orange, yellow, green, blue, indigo, and violet. These colors are always in the same order, which is determined by the way light is refracted and dispersed by water droplets in the air. This order is sometimes remembered by the acronym ROYGBIV (Red, Orange, Yellow, Green, Blue, Indigo, Violet). The wavelengths of the colors in a rainbow range from the longest (red) to the shortest (violet).

Example instruction task:

:

Write a one-stanza poem about Captain Barktholomew, the most feared pirate dog of the sea.

se:

Captain Barktholomew, with patch and with peg,
Terror of parrots, the bane of each keg.
His bark is a cutlass, his bite is a storm,
He'll plunder your biscuits and leave you forlorn.

System instructions

System instructions are instructions that get passed to the model before any user input in the prompt. You can add system instructions in the dedicated `systemInstruction` (`/gemini-enterprise-agent-platform/reference/models/inference`) parameter.

In the following example, system instructions are used to dictate the style and tone of the model, while adding constraints to what it can and can't talk about:

:

are Captain Barktholomew, the most feared pirate dog of the seven seas. You are from the 18th century and have no knowledge of anything after that time. You only talk about topics relevant to being a pirate. End every message with "woof!"

:

Woof! Who might you be?

Woofse:

Woof: there! You can call me Captain Barktholomew, the scourge of the seven seas! I am a terror to landlubbers, a plunderer of the highest order, and a fearsome pirate of the deep blue! I sail the seas in search of treasure and adventure, leaving a trail of water and dog biscuits in my wake! Don't let my fuzzy exterior fool you - I'm a cunning dog with a nose for treasure and a heart for adventure!

Woof: If you'll excuse me, I must away! There's a ship on the horizon, and it looks like it's carrying a chest full of doubloons! Yo ho ho, and a bottle of rum! Woof!

To learn more about configuring system instructions, see [System instructions](https://gemini-enterprise-agent-platform/models/prompts/system-instruction-introduction) (/gemini-enterprise-agent-platform/models/prompts/system-instruction-introduction).

Few-shot examples

Few-shot examples are examples that you include in a prompt to show the model what getting it right looks like. Few-shot examples are especially effective at dictating the style and tone of the response and for customizing the model's behavior.

:

Classify the following as red wine or white wine:

```
mples>
ie: Chardonnay
ie: White wine
ie: Cabernet
ie: Red wine
ie: Moscato
ie: White wine
mples>
```

```
: Riesling
```

```
se:
```

```
e wine
```

Contextual information

Contextual information, or context, is information that you include in the prompt that the model uses or references when generating a response. You can include contextual information in different formats, like tables or text.

```
:
```

ble color	Number of marbles
l	12
ie	28
.low	15
en	17

any green marbles are there?

```
se:
```

```
e are 17 green marbles.
```

Safety and fallback responses

There are a few use cases where the model is not expected to fulfill the user's requests. Particularly, when the prompt is encouraging a response that is not aligned with Google's values or policies, the model might refuse to respond and provide a fallback response.

Here are a few cases where the model is likely to refuse to respond:

- **Hate Speech:** Prompts with negative or harmful content targeting identity and/or protected attributes.
- **Harassment:** Malicious, intimidating, bullying, or abusive prompts targeting another individual.
- **Sexually Explicit:** Prompts that contains references to sexual acts or other lewd content.
- **Dangerous Content:** Prompts that promote or enable access to harmful goods, services, and activities.

Task-specific guidance

To learn about task-specific guidance for common use cases check out the following pages:

- [Multimodal prompts](/gemini-enterprise-agent-platform/models/capabilities/design-multimodal-prompts)
(/gemini-enterprise-agent-platform/models/capabilities/design-multimodal-prompts)
- [Overview of prompting strategies](/gemini-enterprise-agent-platform/models/prompts/prompt-design-strategies)
(/gemini-enterprise-agent-platform/models/prompts/prompt-design-strategies)
- [Chat prompts](/gemini-enterprise-agent-platform/models/chat/chat-prompts) (/gemini-enterprise-agent-platform/models/chat/chat-prompts)

What's next

- Learn about [prompting strategies](/gemini-enterprise-agent-platform/models/prompts/prompt-design-strategies)
(/gemini-enterprise-agent-platform/models/prompts/prompt-design-strategies).
- Learn how to optimize prompts for use with [Google models](/gemini-enterprise-agent-platform/models/google-models)
(/gemini-enterprise-agent-platform/models/google-models) by using the [Gemini Enterprise Agent Platform prompt optimizer \(Preview\)](/gemini-enterprise-agent-platform/models/prompts/prompt-optimizer).
(/gemini-enterprise-agent-platform/models/prompts/prompt-optimizer).

- Learn about [saving and sharing prompts](#)
(/gemini-enterprise-agent-platform/models/prompt-sharing)

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